CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Saturday, November 14, 2026

1,859 words · 7 min read

RE: Trump to decide Australian lamb tariffs · Australia-Philippines defence pact signs Sunday · NZ lamb safeguard advances · Vanuatu sues France over Mathew and Hunter · Fiji sets 605-candidate election field

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
9,082	0.6774	14,174	0.5525
+0.68%	-1.38%	+1.25%	-0.59%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · AUKUS · Pacific · New Zealand · China-Pacific · Canberra · Markets · Documents · Upcoming · The Wire

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. A split US trade commission vote leaves President Trump to decide tariffs on more than $1 billion of Australian lamb exports, with a remedies hearing set for December 1 and a commissioners' report due January 11.
2. Australia and the Philippines sign a defence cooperation agreement Sunday in Manila, expanding reciprocal military access as the Squad grouping of Australia, the United States, the Philippines and Japan builds a joint coordination centre against China's South China Sea pressure.
3. Vanuatu has opened two separate international legal proceedings against France over the Mathew and Hunter islands after two rounds of negotiations failed.

TOP STORIES

TRADE-ECONOMY

Trump to decide tariffs on Australian lamb after US trade panel deadlocks

A tie vote at the US International Trade Commission leaves President **Donald Trump** to decide whether to impose tariffs on Australian lamb, after commissioners split on whether imports have harmed American producers. More than *100,000 tonnes* of Australian lamb, worth over $1 billion, went to the United States last year. A public remedies hearing is set for December 1, with a report due to Trump by January 11. Georgetown University's **Jennifer Hillman**, a former USITC commissioner, said a tie lets the president pick the winning vote.

per ABC News: "Trump to rule on tariffs for Australian lamb after trade commissioners disagree"

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Australia and Philippines to sign defence pact amid South China Sea tensions

Australia and the Philippines are set to sign a defence cooperation agreement on Sunday as **Anthony Albanese** meets senior Philippine officials at the ASEAN summit in Manila. The pact is expected to expand reciprocal military access and information sharing and to bolster the Philippine Navy and coastguard. It advances the informal four-nation grouping nicknamed "the Squad," comprising Australia, the United States, the Philippines and Japan, whose defence officials met in Cebu last month and this week announced a Combined Coordination Centre.

per ABC News: "Australia, Philippines to ink defence deal amid South China Sea tensions"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Forum chair backs Australia's COP31 role as Albanese defends summit costs

The Pacific Islands Forum chair backed Australia's role at COP31 as **Anthony Albanese** defended the cost of hosting and attending the conference. Albanese argued climate action bears directly on Australia's national interest, regional security and its relationships with Pacific Island countries, after domestic criticism of delegation spending. He left Antalya for the ASEAN summit in Manila while Climate Change and Energy Minister **Chris Bowen** stayed on in Türkiye.

per PNG Post-Courier: "Forum Chair backs Australia's COP31 role as Albanese defends conference spending"

OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Climate talks tread water as world leaders stay away from Antalya · ABC News

Organisers counted *94,866* people in Antalya for COP31, including 34,000 national delegates. The United States is absent at national level after **Donald Trump** withdrew from the Paris Agreement a second time. China's **Xi Jinping** sent Vice-President **Han Zheng**; **Narendra Modi**, **Mark Carney** and **Sanae Takaichi** did not attend.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

COP31 hears 1.5C overshoot is not an option for the Pacific · RNZ Pacific

The president of the Marshall Islands told COP31 that any overshoot of 1.5 degrees Celsius is unacceptable for Pacific states. "Every fraction of a degree we warm brings a catastrophe," he said, as Pacific delegations pressed for firmer commitments in Antalya.

US-AUSTRALIA

US airspace reopens after ground stop strands Australian travellers · ABC News

The Federal Aviation Administration lifted a nationwide ground stop triggered by a communications failure affecting 22 regional air route traffic control centres, only the second such grounding since September 11, 2001. More than *11,000 flights* were delayed or cancelled. Sydney Airport said US-bound services resumed after being halted on Saturday morning.

US-CHINA-PACIFIC

PNG observers urge China and US restraint over smuggled artillery shell · PNG Post-Courier

A senior Papua New Guinean communications expert said Washington and Beijing should stop pushing competing narratives and let PNG police handle the case of an allegedly smuggled artillery shell found in a shipping container imported by a Chinese company.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Chinese consulate presses Victoria after delivery rider's fatal stabbing · ABC News

Chinese state media and social platforms amplified the death of 47-year-old Chinese national **Feng Jianming**, a HungryPanda delivery rider stabbed in Melbourne. Consul General **Fang Xinwen** asked the premier, the Victorian government and Victoria Police to handle the case fairly and safeguard the rights of Chinese nationals in Victoria.

STAT OF THE DAY

100,000 tonnes

Australian lamb exported to the United States last year

The shipments, worth more than $1 billion, are now exposed to a tariff decision that falls to President Trump after the USITC split.

ABC News

AUKUS WATCH

PILLARS 1 AND 2 · BREAKING DEFENSE

AUKUS review was the 'best thing' for the trilateral pact, Colby says

Colby said the AUKUS review was the "best thing" for the trilateral pact, framing scrutiny as a strengthener rather than a threat. The report carried no further detail on scope, findings or timeline.

PACIFIC WIRE

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Solomons minister urges faster climate finance disbursement

Climate Change Minister **Wayne Ghemu** told a Pacific Catastrophe Risk Insurance Company panel in Antalya that institutions must speed disbursement before disasters strike. He cited Tropical Cyclone Maila, a Category 5 system that hit Simbo Island in April 2026, affecting about 2,247 residents and displacing 268: PCRIC paid *$500,000* within ten days.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu brings two legal cases against France over Mathew and Hunter

Vanuatu has initiated two separate international legal proceedings against France over sovereignty of the Mathew and Hunter islands, after two rounds of negotiations failed to produce a solution.

PALAU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

North Pacific audit offices train on operational planning in Guam

The Pacific Association of Supreme Audit Institutions ran a five-day workshop to November 13 for 19 senior staff from eight audit offices across the Federated States of Micronesia, Guam, the Marshall Islands and Palau. Programme director **Sinaroseta Palamo-Iosefo** said strong operational planning underpins public-sector accountability.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Eleven parties could field 605 candidates in Fiji's election

Supervisor of Elections **Ana Mataiciwa** said eleven registered parties could field up to *605 candidates* for 55 seats. Electoral Commission chair **Justice Usaia Ratuvili** said the date rests with Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka** and the poll can be held any time up to February 6, 2027. Budget documents allocate $20 million for a possible referendum and $14.82 million for election day.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji keeps ballot counting at polling stations

Justice **Usaia Ratuvili** confirmed ordinary ballots will be counted at polling stations as in 2014, 2018 and 2022, responding to six civil society groups that asked the justice minister not to commence new Section 89A of the Electoral Act 2014, which permits counting at centres. The section stays in law and could be used only on a "credible risk".

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Ngake by-election postponed two weeks over ballot delivery delays

The Ngake constituency by-election in Pukapuka has been pushed back a fortnight because of transport difficulties getting official voting papers to Pukapuka and Nassau.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Australia hands two fast-response vehicles to Vanuatu Fire Service

Australia handed over two fast-response vehicles and specialised fire and rescue equipment to the Vanuatu Fire Service, adding to frontline firefighting and rescue capability.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Seasonal worker questions cost of proposed Vanuatu scheme changes

A Vanuatu seasonal worker has questioned whether proposed changes to the country's seasonal employment system would impose extra financial pressure on workers travelling overseas, a cohort central to Australian and New Zealand labour mobility schemes.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Cook Islands High Court delays first election petition hearing

The hearing of the first of three electoral petitions, listed to begin yesterday morning, was postponed by a day, extending the legal tail on the recent election that returned Prime Minister **Mark Brown** and the Cook Islands Party.

REGIONAL · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Strengthening El Nino forecast to disrupt weather into early 2027

A strengthening El Nino is forecast to disrupt Cook Islands weather, marine ecosystems and tuna fishing grounds through early 2027, with officials urging community preparation. Fiji is already rationing water overnight in Nadi and Lautoka as a prolonged dry spell bites.

NEW ZEALAND

TRADE-ECONOMY · RNZ

Wellington 'deeply disappointed' as US lamb safeguard probe advances

Minister for Trade and Investment **Todd McClay** said New Zealand is deeply disappointed the US International Trade Commission will advance its safeguard investigation into lamb imports to the remedies stage. He has sent officials to Washington for the December 1 hearing. New Zealand sold about *$600 million* of sheep meat to the United States in 2025.

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · NEWSROOM NZ

New Zealand's light touch on pressing China over human rights

Newsroom's The Detail examines what democracies of New Zealand's size can do to raise human rights with Beijing when economic leverage can be turned against political statements, a question sharpened by the trade exposure now running through the lamb dispute with Washington.

NZ-POLITICS · NZ HERALD

Luxon is behaving as if he has won the election

The NZ Herald asks whether **Christopher Luxon** has in fact secured a second term, as he conducts himself as the winner of the November 7 general election while coalition arrangements remain unsettled.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

COOK ISLANDS · MARITIME SURVEY · GLOBAL TIMES STATE MEDIA

Chinese submersible Jiaolong completes 17 Pacific dives before Cook Islands survey

Global Times reports the crewed submersible Jiaolong has completed 17 Pacific dives as China's DY100 ocean expedition prepares a survey in Cook Islands waters. The Cook Islands seabed authority said in October that exploration there runs to 2032.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Albanese and Bowen caught in hot-mic exchange at COP31

Australian media recorded **Anthony Albanese** and **Chris Bowen** joking about phone radiation shortly before a renewable energy investment roundtable in Antalya. The prime minister's office said the pair were sharing a joke between meetings. The Coalition called the exchange "weird and gross" and accused the pair of behaving like "14-year-old schoolboys".

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Few easy policy options left as government mood sours

The ABC reports grimness inside the government, driven by the realisation that few easy policy options remain, and says it is now hard to find people willing to speak warmly of the prime minister even among Labor diehards.

AU-POLITICS · GUARDIAN AUSTRALIA

Labor must make the case for its tax changes as house prices fall

Guardian Australia's **Tom McIlroy** writes that **Anthony Albanese** spent only a few days at home between the Commonwealth summit in the Caribbean and COP31 in Türkiye, leaving voters contending with cost-of-living pressure and falling property prices while Labor's negative gearing changes go unexplained.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Housing correction tests whether voters want cheaper homes

New home lending recorded its steepest ever drop this week, with unit values outperforming houses in most capital cities as the highest interest rates in 18 years shrink borrowing power. The national target of 1.2 million homes in five years is likely doomed, the ABC reports, and **Jim Chalmers** has reframed negative gearing changes as a leg-up for buyers over investors.

AU-POLITICS · SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Who is voting One Nation in Victoria

The Sydney Morning Herald profiles One Nation's Victorian base ahead of the state election, among them a Sri Lankan immigration lawyer handing out for **Pauline Hanson**, a truck driver who says Labor is finished, and a former unionist who has left the party.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · AUSTRALIAN FINANCIAL REVIEW

Housing and AI shocks land on Australia's middle class

The AFR's Chanticleer column says the week laid bare an accelerating housing correction alongside the arrival of an artificial intelligence jobs shock, a combination it expects households to find deeply uncomfortable.

TRADE-ECONOMY · AUSTRALIAN FINANCIAL REVIEW

Afterpay co-founder Nick Molnar to leave Block

Nick Molnar is leaving Block 13 years after co-founding Afterpay, which was sold five years ago for *$39 billion*, the largest takeover of an Australian technology company.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Productivity Commission finds regional airfares far outpace city routes

An interim Productivity Commission report released this week found long regional and remote flights cost *67 percent* more on average than major city routes, and short regional flights 173 percent more per kilometre, a gap now reshaping access for remote communities.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

MINISTERIAL TRANSCRIPT · AUSTRALIAN MINISTER FOR FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Wong takes questions at the United States Studies Centre

The foreign minister's office published a transcript of **Penny Wong**'s question and answer session at the United States Studies Centre. The transcript is the authoritative record of her remarks.

UPCOMING

NOV 2026

Australia-Philippines defence cooperation agreement signing, Manila

Expands reciprocal military access and information sharing as the Squad grouping builds a Combined Coordination Centre.

NOV 2026

Ngake by-election in Pukapuka, Cook Islands

Postponed two weeks over ballot delivery, it is one of the last seats outstanding after the recent general election.

DEC 1

US International Trade Commission remedies hearing on lamb imports, Washington DC

Australia and New Zealand will both argue against safeguard measures on sheep meat exports worth over $1 billion and about $600 million respectively.

JAN 11

USITC commissioners' report to President Trump on lamb safeguards

Sets the options from which the president will choose any tariff or restriction on Australian and New Zealand lamb.

FEB 6

Latest permissible date for Fiji's general election and possible referendum

Eleven parties may field up to 605 candidates for 55 seats, with the date still resting with Prime Minister Rabuka.

THE WIRE

PACIFIC-POLITICS · DEVPOLICY BLOG

Spotlighting type 1 diabetes in the Pacific

Lisa Denney of La Trobe University's Centre for Human Security and Social Change contrasts life-saving technology and support available in Australia with underdiagnosis and insulin shortages across the Pacific, drawing on a parent's first-hand account.

PACIFIC-POLITICS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

What the CIP government must deliver next

Political analyst **William Numanga** writes that the recent election gave Prime Minister **Mark Brown** and the Cook Islands Party a strong mandate for another four years, and sets out what the government now has to deliver.

PACIFIC-POLITICS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Microsoft outage hits Cook Islands government and businesses

A global Microsoft outage disabled email and cloud services across Cook Islands government offices, resorts and banks, forcing officials and businesses onto phone calls, social media and alternative messaging platforms.

PACIFIC-POLITICS · FIJIVILLAGE

Fiji says 24,600 people face water shortages

Fijian authorities said *24,600 people* face water shortages as the dry spell deepens, urging communities to protect vulnerable households. Overnight rationing has begun in Nadi and Lautoka from 9pm to 4am.

PACIFIC-POLITICS · FBC NEWS

Fiji Airways monitors US ground stop for flight delays

Fiji Airways is monitoring the United States ground stop for knock-on delays to its North American services, one of several Pacific carriers exposed to the air traffic control outage.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

Read online · Past issues

You are receiving the Australia Daily Brief as a member of the CSIS Australia Chair distribution list.

This newsletter is automatically generated, so it may contain errors. Please check all information and sources before citing. To report errors or other issues, please contact Andy Lim at alim@csis.org.

generated 6:15 AM ET

↑ BACK TO TOP

© 2026 Center for Strategic and International Studies